

Gïstan (lesson six)

Writing practice (review of subject prefixes)

Write the remaining forms of the paradigm from the two that are provided for each verb:

_____	'I'm washing up.' (hands, maybe also face)
_____	'Wash up.'
_____	'He/she is washing up.'
_____	'We (du.) are washing up.'
lec'iznildekh	'We're washing up.'
lec'iniwhlhdekh	'Wash up (you pl.).'
_____	'They're washing up.'

ïlhghïs	'I itch'
_____	'you itch'
_____	'he/she itches'
	'we (du.) itch'
ts'ïlhghïs	'we itch'
_____	'you (pl.) itch'
_____ or _____	'they itch'

Verbs inflected for object

In Witsuwit'en, if the object of a verb is 'him/her', 'me', 'us', 'you', 'you (pl.)', 'them' then a prefix must be added to the verb. Compare the following:

nyitalh'alh	'he/she will hire you'
yitalh'alh	'he/she will hire him/her'
hibitalh'alh	'he/she will hire them'
stalh'alh (sitalh'alh)	'he/she will hire me'
niwhtalh'alh	'he/she will hire us/you (pl.)'

These object prefixes are very similar to the object of postposition prefixes although there is one major difference, involving the expression of 'him/her/it' which will be mentioned below.

Most of the object prefixes must precede the outer subject prefixes **h-** 'they' and **ts'/z-** 'we'. Here are some examples. Remember that 'they' causes **i** to lengthen to **aa** (and there is no [h]):

niwhaatalh'alh 'they will hire us/you (pl.)'	niwhts'italh'alh 'we will hire you (pl.)'
saatalh'alh 'they will hire me'	
hibaatalh'alh 'they will hire them'	hibiztalh'alh 'we will hire them'
nyaatalh'alh 'they will hire you'	

When **ny-** 'you' and **ts'/z-** 'we' combine, the result is **nts'iy-** (rather than **nyiz-**):

nts'iytalh'alh 'we will hire you'

The only exception to the rule that the object prefixes precede the outer subject prefixes involves **y-** 'him/her/it', which is only used when the subject is 'he/she' or 'they'. In the next example, notice that **h-** 'they' occurs to the left of **y-** 'he/she', and while there is normally a vowel [i] after **y-**, there is no vowel when **y-** is followed by a consonant-vowel sequence which is not part of the final syllable of the word:

hiytalh'alh 'they will hire him/her'

This is like the expression of 'they...him/her' when 'him/her' is the object of a postposition. Remember:

n~nyika'aaninzin	'they want you'
niwhka'aaninzin	'they want you (pl.)'

niwhka'aanīnzin	'they want us'
ska'aanīnzin, sika'aanīnzin	'they want me'
hiyka'nīnzin	'they want him/her/it'

Here is the difference between direct object prefixes and object of postposition prefixes. When the subject is 'I', 'you' (sg. or pl.) or 'we', then there is no object prefix for 'him/her'. The verb is simply interpreted as having a third person object:

ts'italh'alh	'we'll hire him/her'
tac'h'alh	'I'll hire him/her'
talh'alh	'you will hire him/her'

Compare other persons and numbers of direct objects. There is an actual object prefix:

nyitac'h'alh	'I'll hire you'
niwhtac'h'alh	'I'll hire you (pl.)'
niwhtalh'alh hire you (pl.)'	'you will hire us, he/she will hire us, he/she will hire you (pl.)'
hibitac'h'alh	'I'll hire them'
hibitalh'alh	'you (or he/she) will hire them'

Compare third person singular objects of postpositions with first and second person subjects. There the third person singular object prefix is **b(i)**:-

bika'niszin	'I want him/her/it'
bika'nīnzin	'you want him/her/it'
bika'nididzin	'we (du.) want him/her/it'
bika'iznīnzin	'we want him/her/it'
bika'niwhzin	'you (pl.) want him/her/it'

Here is a summary of the similarities and differences between the verbal object prefixes, the nominal possessive prefixes, and the postpositional prefixes.

	nominal possessive prefix	postpositional object prefix	verbal object prefix
1sg 'me', 'my'	s- ~ si-	s- ~ si-	s~ si-
2sg 'you', 'your'	n- ~ nyi-	n- ~ nyi	nyi-
3sg 'him/her', 'his/her', 3 rd subject	bi-	yi-	yi-
3sg 'him/her', 'his/her', non-3 rd subject	bi-	bi-	
1/2pl 'us, you (pl.)', 'our, your (pl.)'	niwh-	niwh-	niwh-
3pl 'them', 'their'	hibi-	hibi-	hibi-

The table also shows that there is a second, minor difference between the verbal object prefixes on the one hand and the possessive and postpositional prefixes, on the other. The second person singular direct object prefix is always **nyi-**. There is no short form **n-** for the second person singular direct object prefix.

Verb formulas

Here are some forms of 'hear, understand':

nyidists'agh	'I hear, understand you'
sdĩnts'agh, sidĩnts'agh	'you hear, understand me'
saadĩts'agh	'they hear, understand me'
nyaadĩts'agh	'they hear, understand you'

The formula or template for 'hear, understand' can be stated as follows:³

_____	_____	dĩ	_____	ts'agh
direct object	outer subject		inner subject	

Remember that the outer subject and inner subject will not both be filled; they are mutually exclusive. Here is how the forms above fit into the formula:

nyi	_____	dĩ	s	ts'agh
direct object	outer subject		inner subject	
s/si	_____	dĩ	n	ts'agh
direct object	outer subject		inner subject	

³This is actually the imperfective formula for this verb. The real formula lacks **ĩ**.

s	aa	dī	_____	ts'agh
direct object	outer subject		inner subject	
ny	aa	dī	_____	ts'agh
direct object	outer subject		inner subject	

Writing practice

Translate and write some of the other forms of this verb in the spaces provided:

'I hear, understand you (pl.)'	_____
'I hear, understand them'	_____
'he/she hears, understands me'	_____
'he/she hears, understands you'	_____
'he/she hears, understands us'	_____
'he/she hears, understands you (pl.)'	_____
'he/she hears, understands him/her'	_____
'he/she hears, understands them'	_____
'you hear, understand us'	_____
'you hear, understand him/her'	_____
'you hear, understand them'	_____
'we hear, understand him/her'	_____
'we hear, understand you'	_____
'we hear, understand you (pl.)'	_____
'we hear, understand them'	_____
'we 2 hear, understand him/her'	_____
'we 2 hear, understand you'	_____
'we 2 hear, understand you (pl.)'	_____
'we 2 hear, understand them'	_____

‘they hear, understand us’

‘they hear, understand you (pl.)’

‘they hear, understand him/her’

‘they hear, understand them’

‘you (pl.) hear, understand me’

‘you (pl.) hear, understand us’

‘you (pl.) hear, understand him/her’

‘you (pl.) hear, understand them’

'see'

The verb 'see' takes a direct object, like 'hear, understand'. But the imperfective is actually formed with the progressive prefix, which varies between **ĩ** and **ë**. Study the forms below:

ĩs'ën 'I see him/her/it'**së'ën** 'he/she sees me'**nts'iyĩ'ën** 'we see you (sg.)'**niwhën'ën** 'you (sg.) see us'**hibĩ'ën** 'he/she/it sees them'**hiyĩ'ën** 'they see him/her/it'

The imperfective formula for 'see' can be given as follows:

_____	_____	ĩ/ë	_____	'ën
direct object	outer subject		inner subject	

Here is how the above forms fit the formula:

ĩs'ën 'I see him/her/it':

_____	_____	ĩ	s	'ën
direct object	outer subject		inner subject	

së'ën 'he/she sees me':

s	_____	ë	_____	'ën
direct object	outer subject		inner subject	

nts'iyĩ'ën 'we see you (sg.)':

nts'iy	_____	ĩ	_____	'ën
direct object+outer subject			inner subject	

niwhën'ën 'you (sg.) see us':

niwh	_____	ë	n	'ën
direct object	outer subject		inner subject	

hibi'ën 'he/she/it sees them':

hib	_____	ï	_____	'ën
direct object	outer subject		inner subject	

hiyi'ën 'they see him/her/it':

hiy	_____	ï	_____	'ën
direct object+outer subject			inner subject	

More practice with object prefixes

Now you try translating and writing some of the other forms of 'see' below"

_____	'I see you'
_____	'I see you (pl.)'
_____	'I see them'
_____	'we (du.) see you'
_____	'we (du.) see you (pl.)'
_____	'we (du.) see him/her/it'
_____	'we (du.) see them'
_____	'we see you (pl.)'
_____	'we see him/her/it'
_____	'we see them'
_____	'you see me'
_____	'you see him/her/it'
_____	'you see them'
_____	'you (pl.) see me'
_____	'you (pl.) see us'
_____	'you (pl.) see him/her/it'

'you (pl.) see them'

'he/she/it sees us'

'he/she/it sees you'

'he/she/it sees you (pl.)'

'he/she/it sees him/her/it'

'they see me'

'they see us'

'they see you (pl.)'

Postscript to writing practice

There are two more forms of 'see' which may or may not surprise you.

nyee'ën 'they see you'

hibee'ën 'they see them'

It may not surprise you that the prefix vowel is not **ë**, because this vowel does not occur after **y** or **b**, but it may be a surprise that the vowel is **e**, not **ï**. Here is how these forms fit the template for 'see':

nyee'ën 'they see you':

(abstractly)

ny	h	ï/ë	—	'ën
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direct object	outer subject		inner subject
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--> ny(i)-h-ï/ë-'ën

--> ny-ee-'ën

hibee'ën 'they see them':

(abstractly)

hib	h	ï/ë	—	'ën
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direct object	outer subject		inner subject
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--> hib(i)-h-ï/ë-'ën

--> hib-ee-'ën

Neniwhost'ën 'I will see you (pl.) later'